

WHAT'S IN A NAME? Ravenshaw University, which was established as a college in Cuttack in 1868

ARABINDA MAHAPATRA

ODISHA

CONTESTED LEGACY

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

From July 1937 until the foundation of Bhubaneswar as Odisha's capital in 1949, the assembly hall of Ravenshaw College in Cuttack served as the venue for the state's newly set up legislative assembly. It is almost symbolic that the institution that shaped the minds of many Odia luminaries was the first seat of recognition of its statehood. Now, this 156-year-old institution finds itself at the centre of a debate about colonial legacy and Odia identity after Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan recently suggested that its name be disassociated from that of British administrator Thomas Edward Ravenshaw, who played a key role in its establishment.

And why has the minister taken this stand? Because, as the Commissioner of Bengal Presidency's Orissa division, Ravenshaw was at the helm during the *Na'Anka Durbhikshya* or Great Orissa Famine of 1866, which is estimated to have claimed over a million lives. Anil Biswal, a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) spokesperson, blames Ravenshaw for these deaths. He says Pradhan's suggestion was part of an attempt to point to this part of the colonial legacy, and argue for ceasing to honour it. It's for the people to take a call on it, he adds.



THE KEY DEBATE

↘ Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan wants Ravenshaw University's name disassociated from that of British administrator Thomas Edward Ravenshaw, who was in charge during the Great Orissa Famine of 1866

↘ But the 156-year-old institution's alumni and historians argue that Ravenshaw's contributions towards education and Odia identity outweigh his failure during the famine